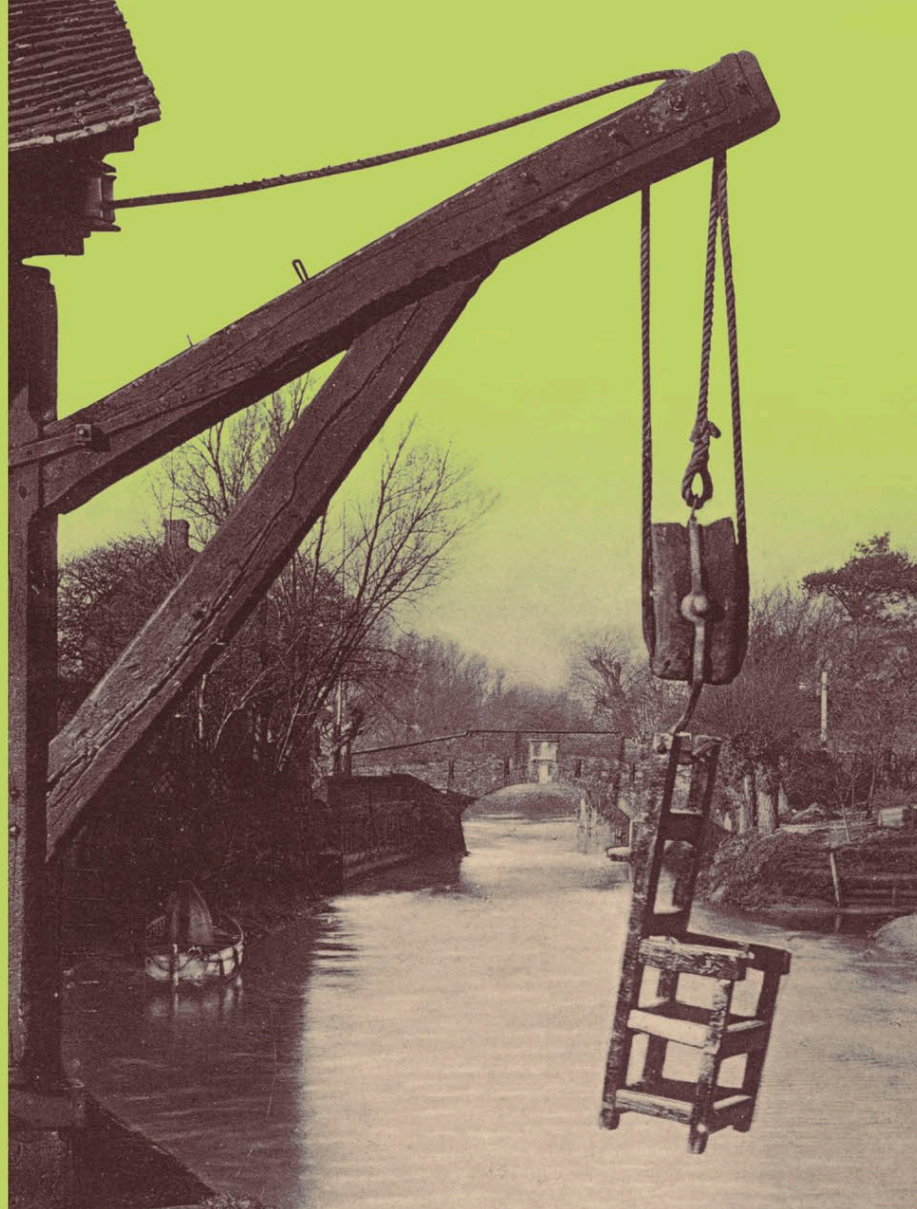




Native Americans had their own ideas about witchcraft. It was believed that its practitioners could cause bad luck, and some communities thought witches could transform into or possess animals (called “skin-walkers” by the Navajo). Suspected witches, often older women, were captured and tortured before being warned, banished, or killed. Dislocation and disease caused by contact with western settlers increased accusation of witchcraft within indigenous communities.

Modern witches

Belief in witchcraft continues to exist in many places, especially in Africa, where tribal societies often make a distinction between “good” witch doctors and more malign witches, the latter being mostly women. While there has been sporadic persecution of witches in some African countries, the continent has never had a mass witch-hunt on the scale of those that occurred in Europe or the United States.

▲ Ducking stool trial

Some women suspected of witchcraft were ducked into ponds and rivers to ascertain their guilt – if they swam, they were considered culpable.



PROFILES

ACCUSED WITCHES

Alice Kyteler (c.1263–1325) was a prosperous Irish woman who had been married four times. In 1324 she was accused of witchcraft by her stepchildren. The local bishop led an investigation against her, charging her with a range of offenses: denying Christ, making offerings to demons, creating potions, and using sorcery to kill her late husbands. She fled the country to avoid execution.

Hwi-bin Kim (1410–1429) was the daughter of a senior Korean official, and in 1427 was chosen as consort for Munjong, the king's heir. Kim apparently used witchcraft to win Munjong's favor, as he was still interested in other women at court. She burned her rivals' shoes and tried to enchant Munjong by wearing a cloth covered with snake blood. When her actions were revealed, she was driven from court and relegated to the rank of commoner.

Merga Bien (d. 1603) was from the German town of Fulda. In 1602, its ruler instituted a witch-hunt that led to the condemnation of over 200 people. Bien had been married to her third husband for 14 years but had only just become pregnant. She was accused of witchcraft as it was believed she had conceived through consorting with the Devil. Under torture, she was forced to admit this, and to killing her second husband. Bien was then burned alive.

Catherine Monvoisin (c.1640–1680), known as “La Voison,” was a French midwife, fortune-teller, and seller of aphrodisiacs. In Paris, she grew wealthy through telling the fortunes of the country's aristocrats, including the king's mistress. In 1679, Monvoisin was accused of being at the center of a poisoning and black magic ring; a year later she was burned at the stake for witchcraft.

Marie Laveau (c.1794/1801–1881) was born into a free black family in New Orleans. She was an acclaimed practitioner of voodoo, which was based on traditional beliefs brought to North America by enslaved Africans. Laveau sold lucky amulets called “gris-gris,” performed enchantments, predicted the future, and even healed the sick. Due to her powers she became known as the “Voodoo Queen” of New Orleans.